Arafat indeed deserved a large share of the blame: the PLO helped to organize the riots, and his security forces joined the fighting. But so did Netanyahu, who approved the plan without notifying his generals, many of whom said they learned about it only after the tunnel was opened. Once the fighting stopped, he maneuvered to place the blame on the security services, a move which only angered them further.

Lipkin-Shahak gave his response a few weeks later, at a memorial service on the first anniversary of Rabin's murder. In an emotional speech addressed to his former commander, the general lamented the army's "fall from grace" over the past year. "Polarization, hedonism, sectarianism [and] apathy… have penetrated the nation's consciousness, and decimated consensus," he said, "transforming the IDF from one of our most hallowed institutions into a collective punching bag."[7] It was a scathing address—a direct criticism of the political establishment from a serving army chief. Ze'ev Maoz, a military analyst, started speculating publicly about a coup.

The putsch didn't happen, but a general took power nonetheless. Netanyahu's government collapsed in 1998, largely over the Wye River Memorandum, an interim agreement with the Palestinians. Lipkin-Shahak announced that he would run for office, as did Yitzhak Mordechai, who was Netanyahu's defense minister—a particularly humiliating rebuke to Bibi. Both men eventually bowed out, however, and consolidated their support behind Ehud Barak, who swept to power with 56 per cent of the popular vote.

"This is, indeed, the dawn of a new day," Barak said on election night, before a crowd of supporters in Tel Aviv's Rabin Square. "It is time to end the division and to find harmony."[8]

It would take Netanyahu a full decade to climb back to power. But he learned a lesson from his defeat, and began laying the groundwork for his second term in 2007, when he was the opposition leader. The Knesset lengthened the "cooling-off period" for security officials, barring them from politics for three years after retirement, a sixfold increase from the previous law. The bill was drafted by Yuval Steinitz, a Likud lawmaker who has long been a close Netanyahu confidante. "This is a big day for Israeli democracy," Steinitz said after the vote. "For the first time, we have positioned a wall between the IDF and politics."[9]

For twenty years, Netanyahu has made a simple pitch to Israeli voters. "In a chaotic, dangerous region, I will keep you safe." The only challengers